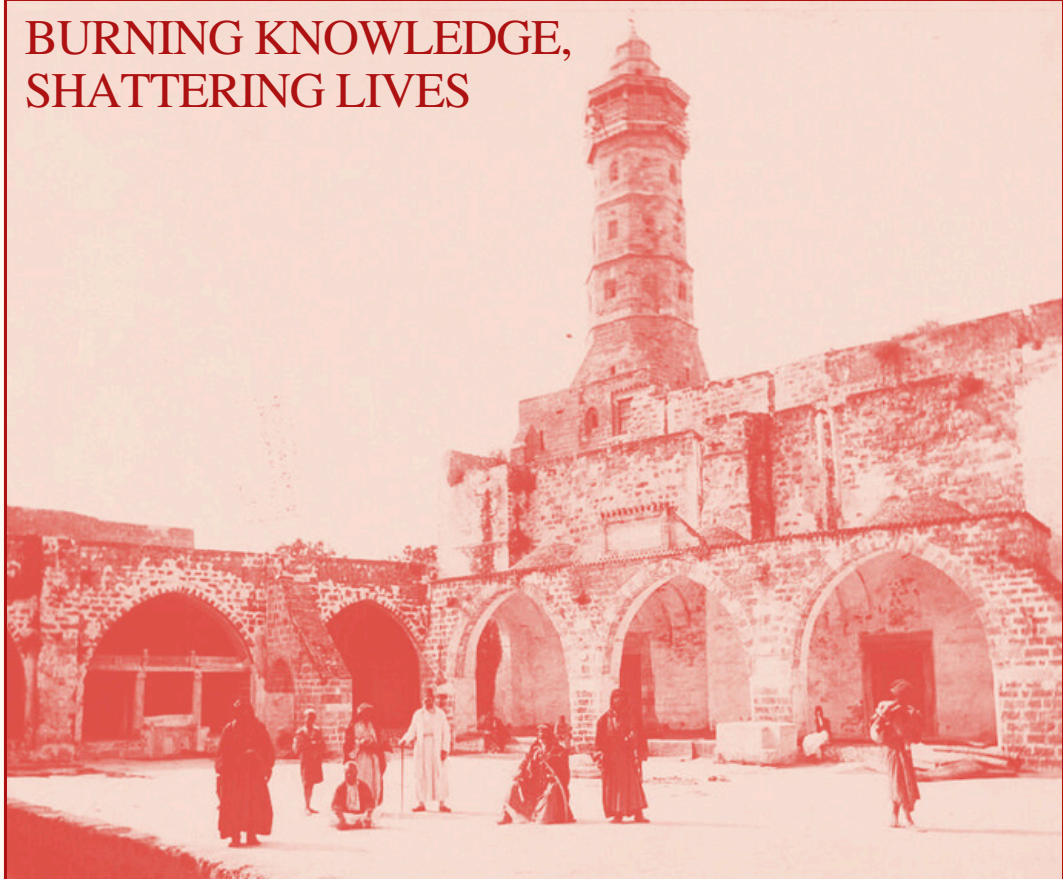


BURNING KNOWLEDGE,
SHATTERING LIVES

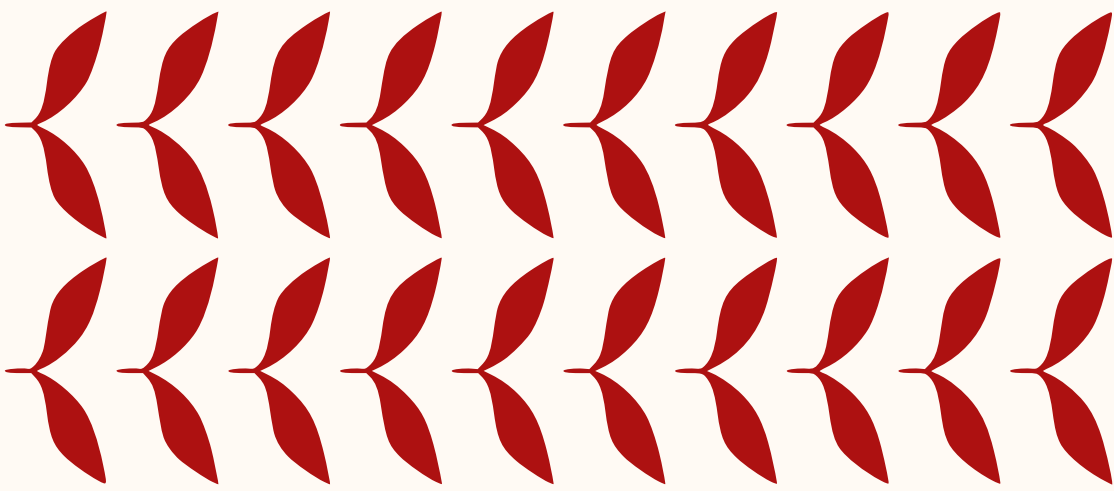
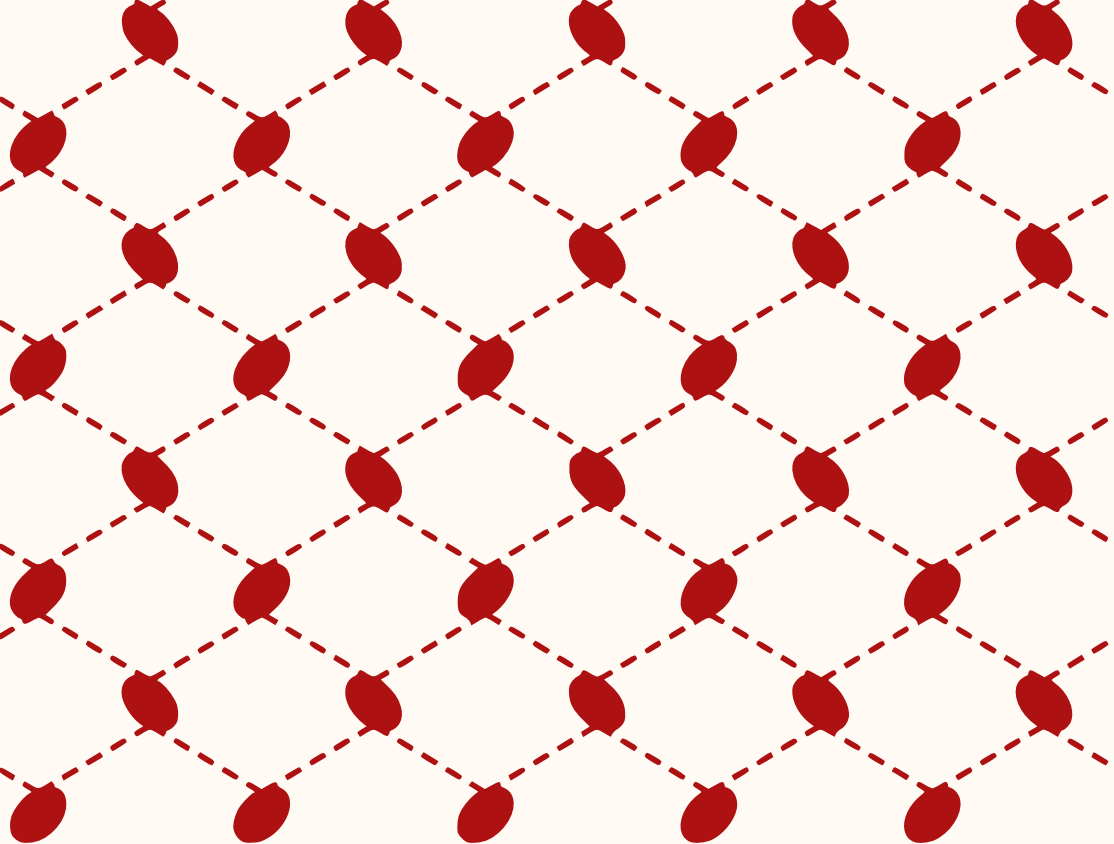


Omari Mosque & Library, Gaza City c. 1867 by Maison Bonfils

RANGANATHAN'S FIVE LAWS IN THE SHADOWS OF GENOCIDE

Abandoned Affair







In memory of all the martyrs.
The many librarians, archivists,
and scholars who have
been massacred by the
occupation in Gaza since
October 7th 2023, and in all
of Occupied Palestine
since the Nakba in 1948.

In memory of the libraries that
have been demolished, the
books that will never be read,
and the history stolen by
the occupation.

May knowledge and wisdom
rise from the ashes
of genocide.



THE PURPOSE OF THIS ZINE

S.R. Ranganathan's (1931) Five Laws of Library Science emphasize accessibility, preservation, and the continued growth of knowledge and information.

In stark contrast, the physical and cultural genocide in Gaza and Occupied Palestine demonstrates a systematic effort to erase Palestinian history, culture, and education through the targeted destruction of libraries, archives, and academic institutions—as documented in reports such as the **Librarians and Archivists with Palestine (LAP) - Gaza Report 2024**.

This zine will introduce each of Ranganathan's five laws, and demonstrate how each law has been violated in Gaza and Occupied Palestine, as well as why this is relevant.





STATISTICS & FACTS

(Librarians and Archivists with Palestine, 2024)

Since October 7th 2023, at least 12 major public and university libraries have been completely destroyed by Israeli forces in Gaza.

The 7th century Omari Mosque in Gaza City was bombed and completely destroyed, including its library which housed rare books and manuscripts dating back to the 14th century.

The Diana Tamari Sabbagh Library in Gaza City was reduced to rubble, destroying tens of thousands of books.

The Gaza Municipal Library in Gaza City caught fire after an Israeli airstrike, burning thousands of books beyond recovery.

The Samir Mansour Bookshop and Library in Gaza City, home to over 100,000 books, was destroyed twice, first in 2021 and again in 2023.

The Lubbud, Al-Nahda, and Al-Shorouq Al-Daem Libraries, as well as the Islamic University of Gaza, Al-Israa University, and Al-Quds Open University libraries in Gaza City were all destroyed.

During the Nakba in 1948, Zionist forces looted 30,000 books and manuscripts from Palestinian homes and libraries.

The deliberate destruction of cultural heritage is classified as a war crime and has been prosecuted by the International Criminal Court. The United Nations Human Rights Council (UNHCR, 2016) recognizes that destroying cultural heritage threatens stability, cultural identity, and peace.

Countless librarians, archivists, and scholars have been displaced, injured or killed by Israeli forces, in addition to tens of thousands of civilians, mostly women and children.





These statistics do not just represent destruction—they represent a targeted attack on knowledge, identity, and history. By destroying libraries, archives, museums, and universities, the occupation seeks to erase Palestinian culture from the historical record.



This is **not** collateral damage; it is an intentional cultural **genocide**.

(Librarians and Archivists with Palestine, 2024)



LAW 1: BOOKS ARE FOR USE

Books exist to be read and shared, not to be locked away or destroyed (Ranganathan, 1931).

Violations in Palestine:

- Libraries, archives, and bookstores have been deliberately bombed and burned to the ground in Gaza and the West Bank.
- The Diana Tamari Sabbagh Library and Gaza Municipal Library were obliterated by Israeli airstrikes, erasing access to tens of thousands of books.
- Samir Mansour Bookshop, Gaza's largest bookstore and library, has been destroyed twice—in 2021 and again in October 2023

(Librarians and Archivists with Palestine, 2024)

What This Means:

- Books cannot be used if they are burned, lost under the rubble, or locked behind oppressive barriers. The American Library Association (ALA, 2009) has condemned the destruction of libraries in Gaza, calling for the protection of knowledge as a fundamental right.



LAW 2: EVERY READER THEIR BOOK

Every reader should have access to the books they need, regardless of their background or status (Ranganathan, 1931).

Violations in Palestine:

- Blockades and censorship have restricted access to books, academic materials, and even digital knowledge in Gaza.
- The Israeli siege has blocked shipments of books and school supplies, preventing access to education even before the recent genocide.
- Targeting of university libraries—such as the Islamic University of Gaza Library, which was completely destroyed—deprives students and scholars of crucial academic materials

(Librarians and Archivists with Palestine, 2024)

What This Means:

- When an entire population is denied access to books and education, their ability to learn, grow, and resist oppression is diminished. This law is a direct call for equity in access to knowledge, something inherently denied to Palestinians.



LAW 3: EVERY BOOK ITS READER

No book should go unread—libraries should work to connect readers with the materials they need (Ranganathan, 1931).

Violations in Palestine:

- The destruction of libraries, paired with the mass killing of scholars, librarians, and students, ensures that books and knowledge have no readers left.
- The killing of librarians and academics, such as Doaa Al-Masri (librarian at the Edward Said Library) and Dr. Refaat Alareer (poet and professor at the Islamic University of Gaza), is an intentional intellectual genocide.
- The looting of Palestinian archives by Israeli forces since 1948 ensures that Palestinian history is inaccessible, preventing people from connecting with their own heritage. The UNHRC (2016) recognizes the right of all people to access their cultural heritage, and condemns the destruction of cultural institutions as a violation of international human rights.

(Librarians and Archivists with Palestine, 2024)

What This Means:

- Denying a population access to books and education hinders growth and resistance. This law demands equity in knowledge—something Palestinians are methodically denied.



LAW 4: SAVE THE READER'S TIME

Libraries should be organized and accessible so that readers can easily find the information they need (Ranganathan, 1931).

Violations in Palestine:

- Instead of saving the time of the reader, Palestinians spend their time searching for destroyed archives, lost history, stolen knowledge, and seeking safety from 2,000 lb bombs.
- The obliteration of university libraries such as Al-Israa University Library, which contained thousands of research materials, means Palestinian students waste years trying to reconstruct lost knowledge.
- The deliberate erasure of Palestinian records, such as the complete destruction of Gaza's Central Archives, eliminates access to vital historical and legal documents.

(Librarians and Archivists with Palestine, 2024)

What This Means:

- This law demands efficiency and access, yet destroying Palestinian knowledge systems erases decades of progress, forcing generations to restart.



LAW 5: THE LIBRARY IS A GROWING ORGANISM

Libraries should expand and evolve to meet the needs of society.
(Ranganathan, 1931).

Violations in Palestine:

- Instead of growth, Palestinian libraries are being systematically erased.
- The total destruction of museums, archives, and cultural centers (such as the Rafah Museum, which housed over 3,500 artifacts) means that Palestinian knowledge is actively shrinking rather than growing.
- The Israeli military detonated the last remaining buildings of Al-Israa University, ensuring there is no infrastructure left for knowledge to flourish

(Librarians and Archivists with Palestine, 2024)

What This Means:

- Libraries should be growing, but in Palestine, they are being systematically reduced to nothing. The destruction of knowledge is a long-term strategy of cultural genocide.





In Gaza and Occupied Palestine,
Ranganathan's Five Laws **do not** apply.

Books **are not** for use—because they are
burned, banned, and blocked by the
occupation.

Every reader **does not** have their book—
because their libraries, schools, and
universities have been bombed.

Every book **has no** reader—because
librarians, scholars, and students are
being slaughtered.

Time **is not** saved—it is wasted
searching for what was destroyed and
seeking safety from bombs.

Libraries **are not** growing—they are
instead being obliterated.





Rebuilding is **urgent**. For every lost book, every destroyed library, and every murdered librarian, scholar, and student, we must respond with relentless preservation, reconstruction, and resistance.

The UNHRC (2016) calls for the restoration of cultural heritage as a vital part of humanitarian assistance, recognizing the need to support displaced communities in regaining access to their history.

International solidarity is crucial. Librarians, archivists, scholars, and cultural workers worldwide must amplify Palestinian voices, preserve their narratives, and demand accountability.

Support must extend beyond mourning—through funding reconstruction, documenting lost knowledge, and ensuring Palestinian memory cannot be erased.

This is not just about rebuilding what was lost, but defending the right to exist, learn, and remember.



WHAT YOU CAN DO



Advocate for Palestinian Knowledge and Memory

- Raise awareness about the destruction of Palestinian libraries, archives, and cultural sites.
- Speak out against Israel's theft of Palestinian cultural property and push for repatriation of looted materials.
- Host public discussions, panels, or lectures in your institution to highlight these issues.

Preserve and Digitize Palestinian History

- Work with Palestinian institutions to digitally preserve endangered manuscripts, oral histories, and documents.
- Ensure that Palestinian sources and narratives are included in academic and archival collections.
- Support and contribute to digital archiving projects like the **Palestinian Museum Digital Archive**.

Demand Institutional Accountability

- Pressure libraries, museums, and archives to cut ties with institutions complicit in erasing Palestinian history.
- Advocate for boycotts of Israeli cultural institutions that benefit from stolen Palestinian materials.
- Refuse funding, collaborations, or partnerships with organizations that uphold Israeli apartheid.



WHAT YOU CAN DO CONT.



Provide Direct Aid to Palestinian Cultural Workers

- Donate to efforts restoring Gaza's libraries and archives, including **Matloub**, **Riwaq**, and **LAP**.
- Offer scholarships, fellowships, and residencies to displaced Palestinian scholars, archivists, and students.
- Help secure emergency grants for Palestinian cultural workers impacted by war and displacement.

Speak Out and Mobilize Your Profession

- Pass resolutions in cultural institutions condemning the destruction of Palestinian heritage.
- Join professional solidarity networks like **LAP**.
- Urge colleagues to sign petitions, join protests, and publicly call for a permanent ceasefire and cultural restitution.

Share **Palestinian Narratives and Knowledge**

- Decolonize library and archival collections by amplifying Palestinian voices.
- Ensure Palestinian history is accurately represented in metadata, cataloging, and descriptions.
- Teach and recommend Palestinian books, films, and research in academic and cultural spaces.





Solidarity must be active.
Protecting knowledge
means defending those
who create, preserve, and
share it. Librarians,
archivists, and cultural
workers must stand against
cultural genocide and
historical erasure—not just
in words, but through
concrete action.



IN HONOUR OF



Dr. Refaat Alareer – Poet, writer, and professor of literature at the Islamic University of Gaza, assassinated in an Israeli airstrike.

Doaa Al-Masri – Librarian at the Edward Said Library, killed along with her parents and siblings.

Iman Abu Saeed – Oral historian at the Tamer Institute for Community Education, killed with her children and husband.

Abdul Karim Hashash – Writer and dedicated advocate for Palestinian heritage, collector of rare Palestinian books. Killed on October 23, 2023, along with many family members.

Bilal Jadallah – Director of Press House Palestine, an institution dedicated to journalistic freedom and cultural documentation, killed on November 19, 2023.

Dr. Jihad Suleiman Al-Masri – Historian and Director of Al-Quds Open University (Khan Younis Branch).

And the countless many martyrs and steadfast survivors.

(Librarians and Archivists with Palestine, 2024)

“This library is my whole life. I was shocked when the Israeli occupation decided to bomb the building. It felt like I myself had been destroyed.” (Mansour as cited in Amer, 2021)

“When I saw thousands of books destroyed and lying on the ground, I felt that my own heart had been destroyed.” (Omar as cited in Amer, 2021)

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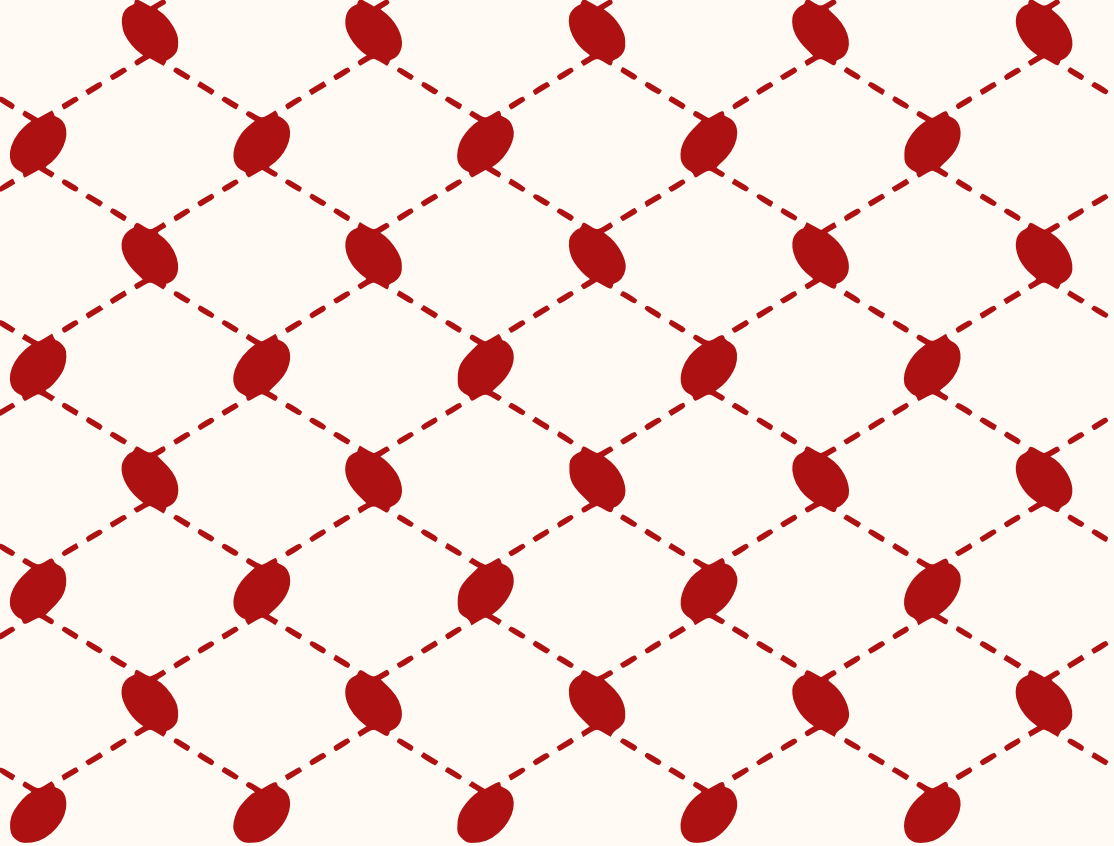


If I must die,
you must live
to tell my story
to sell my things
to buy a piece of cloth
and some strings,
(make it white with a long tail)
so that a child, somewhere in Gaza
while looking heaven in the eye
awaiting his dad who left in a blaze—
and bid no one farewell
not even to his flesh
not even to himself—
sees the kite, my kite you made, flying up above,
and thinks for a moment an angel is there
bringing back love
If I must die
let it bring hope
let it be a tale

Refaat Alareer

September 23, 1979 - December 6, 2023

فلسطين حرةً



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